

The Label Decoder

Consumer Rising · 12 ingredients to watch, and the exact words to look for

HIGHER CONCERN

High Fructose Corn Syrup

Look for: HFCS, HFCS-55, Glucose-fructose syrup, Isoglucose
A cheap liquid sweetener made from corn starch

HIGHER CONCERN

Red 40

Look for: Allura Red AC, E129, FD&C Red No. 40
One of the most widely used artificial colors in US food — candy, drinks, cereals, and snacks

HIGHER CONCERN

Yellow 5

Look for: Tartrazine, E102, FD&C Yellow No. 5
The bright yellow dye in candy, drinks, chips, and even some medicines

HIGHER CONCERN

Partially Hydrogenated Oils

Look for: PHOs, Partially hydrogenated soybean oil, Shortening (some)
The main source of artificial trans fat

HIGHER CONCERN

Brominated Vegetable Oil (BVO)

Look for: BVO, E443
Used to keep citrus flavor mixed in some sodas and sports drinks

HIGHER CONCERN

Potassium Bromate

Look for: Bromated flour, E924
A flour additive that makes bread rise higher and look whiter

HIGHER CONCERN

BHA

Look for: Butylated hydroxyanisole, E320
A preservative that keeps fats in chips, cereal, and gum from going stale

WORTH KNOWING

Sodium Benzoate

Look for: E211, Benzoic acid (related)
A preservative that keeps sodas, juices, and condiments from spoiling

WORTH KNOWING

Aspartame

Look for: E951, NutraSweet, Equal
The sweetener in most diet sodas and sugar-free gum

WORTH KNOWING

Titanium Dioxide

Look for: E171, CI 77891
Makes candy, frosting, and coffee creamer look bright white

LOWER CONCERN

Monosodium Glutamate (MSG)

Look for: MSG, E621, Yeast extract (similar), Hydrolyzed protein (similar)
A flavor booster for savory food

LOWER CONCERN

Carrageenan

Look for: E407, Irish moss (source)
A thickener from red seaweed in chocolate milk, ice cream, and plant milks